

new to GNU/Linux, this is your chance to learn. Finally, it's "Goodbye from YALI" and you've hit the *Next* button to reboot the machine to "Enjoy your fresh Pardus!"

Bottom line: Although you only install an OS once, YALI still leaves a good impression. And I hate the fact that I won't be using it as often as I would use, say Firefox or Amarok. However, I would love to use it over and over again on other people's systems—*anyone game for it?*

Kapitan helps you get started

The GRUB boot screen after install will list all the other distros installed on your system. The system boots to the KDM screen (if you haven't set the user on auto log-in) seriously fast, thanks to MUDUR, the Pardus home-grown *init* system. The KDM screen looks customised with the only options being: enter user name, password, login or quit to shut down/reboot/suspend the system. This is where I realised that hitting F3 and setting the screen resolution earlier had set 1280x1024px as the default resolution post installation—quite impressive, considering it's using Vesa, and not the proprietary drivers from Nvidia.

Upon your first login, the Kapitan greets you. Kapitan is nothing but a *click-next* wizard to set up your desktop. It starts off with mouse settings (Figure 2), then the desktop layout style (placement of panel, and the ability to replace the default KDE3 menu with Kickoff), followed by setting the number of workspaces. Then comes the wallpaper (by default there is no wallpaper—I chose *Canis aureus 02*, the one for this release, which has a nice artwork of a running wolf, fox, jackal, or something similar). Then came network set-up.

This is interesting, as on my laptop, it listed the wlan0 interface, and allowed me to configure it out of the box, with no requirement to load the Broadcom drivers first. The final option before a 'Goodbye' from the Kapitan is the ability to configure package manager settings. This is where you can set the parameters for updates, like show an icon on the system tray, the interval to check for updates, and add the 'contrib' repository. Every time it requires a system-level change like while configuring the network or setting 'contrib' repository in the package manager, it prompts for authentication.

In fact, the final 'Goodbye' screen is handy too. It has the option to reconfigure your graphics. While testing it on VirtualBox, it even reported that the resolution was too low (being at 800 x 600). I noticed a second spelling mistake here—the first one was somewhere in the installer. It said, "You can change your resolution *bye* using Display Manager." On my AMD system, launching the display manager prompted me that I might be better off using the Nvidia v177.x driver in my system, instead of the default Vesa. Later on I found that v180.x is also available in the software repository, and although I had installed it later using the package manager, the display manager continued to report that I might be better off with v177.x. Strange.

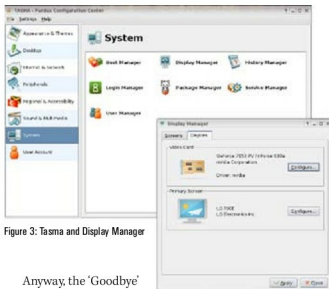


Figure 3: Tasma and Display Manager

Anyway, the 'Goodbye' screen also introduces you to Tasma, the Pardus configuration centre, and the *User Group* and *Help* pages. Upon clicking the *Start* button of the latter it launches Firefox to take you to the 'Contact' page of the Pardus website, which lists information on mailing lists, IRC, Bugzilla, etc.

Tasma helps you configure

At first glance, it looks like the Pardus team has re-branded KControl to Tasma. However, unlike KControl, the home screen explains the purpose of this tool. The broad categories on the left panel are the same like KControl, and so are the modules for these individual sections. Oh, wait a second, a lot of third-party modules have also been integrated into it, and there're more modules to be accessed using *Settings→Show Extra Modules*. These essentially make it similar to the Mandriva Control Centre or SuSE's YAST.

One very cool module I chanced upon here is the *History Manager*. It lets you take snapshots of the system and roll back to a previous system state if something goes wrong. Although I didn't get a chance to break the system and then try this out, my understanding of this tool is that, besides giving you the ability to take snapshots of the system state manually, it also keeps a log of package installs and removals as per their date and time, and thus essentially gives you the privileges of rolling back to a previous state.

Other modules include: user configuration, firewall set-up, network manager, desktop sharing, display manager, TV card configuration, service manager, package manager, etc. Refer to Figure 3.

Apps helps you get the work done

Back to the desktop, I like the fact that the developers haven't overloaded the desktop with too many shortcut icons. In fact, by default, it's just the *System* icon (which is configured to load the sysinfo KIO slave), *Home* and *Trash*.